

LESSON NO 9

Nature of Ethical problems & their solution



Two approaches in the study of ethics

- Micro-ethics
- &
- Macro-ethics



VARIETY OF MORAL ISSUES

- It would be relevant to know why and how do moral issues (problems) arise in a profession or why do people behave unethically?
- The reasons for people including the employer and employees, behaving unethically may be classified into three categories:
 1. Resource Crunch
 2. Opportunity
 3. Attitude

Resource Crunch

- Due to pressure, through time limits, availability of money or budgetary constraints, and technology decay or obsolescence. Pressure from the government to complete the project in time (e.g., before the elections), reduction in the budget because of sudden war or natural calamity (e.g., Tsunami) and obsolescence due to technology innovation by the competitor lead to manipulation and unsafe and unethical execution of projects.
- Involving individuals in the development of goals and values and developing policies that allow for individual diversity, dissent, and input to decision-making will prevent unethical results

Opportunity

- (a) Double standards or behavior of the employers towards the employees and the public. The unethical behaviors of World Com (in USA), Enron (in USA as well as India) executives in 2002 resulted in bankruptcy for those companies,
- (b) Management projecting their own interests more than that of their employees. Some organizations over-emphasize short-term gains and results at the expense of themselves and others,
- (c) Emphasis on results and gains at the expense of the employees, and
- (d) Management by objectives, without focus on empowerment and improvement of the infrastructure. This is best encountered by developing policies that allow 'conscience keepers' and whistle blowers and appointing ombudsman, who can work confidentially with people to solve the unethical problems internally.

Attitude

- (a) Poor attitude of the employees set in due to
 - (a) Low morale of the employees because of dissatisfaction and downsizing,
 - (b) Absence of grievance redressal mechanism,
 - (c) Lack of promotion or career development policies or denied promotions,
 - (d) Lack of transparency,
 - (e) Absence of recognition and reward system, and
 - (f) Poor working environments.
- Giving ethics training for all, recognizing ethical conduct in work place, including ethics in performance appraisal, and encouraging open discussion on ethical issues, are some of the directions to promote positive attitudes among the employees. To get firm and positive effect, ethical standards must be set and adopted by the senior management, with input from all personnel.

TYPES OF INQUIRIES

- The three types of inquiries, in solving ethical problems are: normative inquiry, conceptual inquiry, and factual or descriptive inquiry.
 1. Normative Inquiry
 2. Conceptual Inquiry
 3. Factual or Descriptive Inquiry
- The three types of inquiries are discussed below to illustrate the differences and preference.

Framing the Problems

- Determining the Facts
- Known and unknown
- Weighing the importance of facts



Issues Pertaining to ethical problem solving method

- Moral Issues
- Conceptual Issues
- Factual Issues

Normative Inquiry

- It seeks to identify and justify the morally-desirable norms or standards that should guide individuals and groups. It also has the theoretical goal of justifying particular moral judgments. Normative questions are about what ought to be and what is good, based on moral values. For example,
 1. How far does the obligation of engineers to protect public safety extend in any given situation?
 2. When, if ever, should engineers be expected to blow whistle on dangerous practices of their employers?
 3. Whose values ought to be primary in making judgment about acceptable risks in design for a public transport system or a nuclear plant? Is it of management, senior engineers, government, voters or all of them?
 4. When and why is the government justified in interfering with the organisations?
 5. What are the reasons on which the engineers show their obligations to their employees or clients or the public?

Conceptual Inquiry

- It is directed to clarify the meaning of concepts or ideas or principles that are expressed by words or by questions and statements. For example,
 - (a) What is meant by safety?
 - (b) How is it related to risk?
 - (c) What is a bribe?
 - (d) What is a profession?
- When moral concepts are discussed, normative and conceptual issues are closely interconnected.

Factual or Descriptive Inquiry

- It is aimed to obtain facts needed for understanding and resolving value issues. Researchers conduct factual inquiries using mathematical or statistical techniques. The inquiry provide important information on business realities, engineering practice, and the effectiveness of professional societies in fostering moral conduct, the procedures used in risk assessment, and psychological profiles of engineers. The facts provide not only the reasons for moral problems but also enable us to develop alternative ways of resolving moral problems. For example,
 1. How were the benefits assessed?
 2. What are procedures followed in risk assessment?
 3. What are short-term and long-term effects of drinking water being polluted?
and
 4. Who conducted the tests on materials?



THIS WAY

THAT WAY 

Ethical dilemma

Definition

&

Example

Dilemma Situations

- Vagueness
- Conflicting reasons
- Disagreement



Steps to Solve Dilemma

- Define
- Effects
- Method
- Other side
- Disclose



Ethical

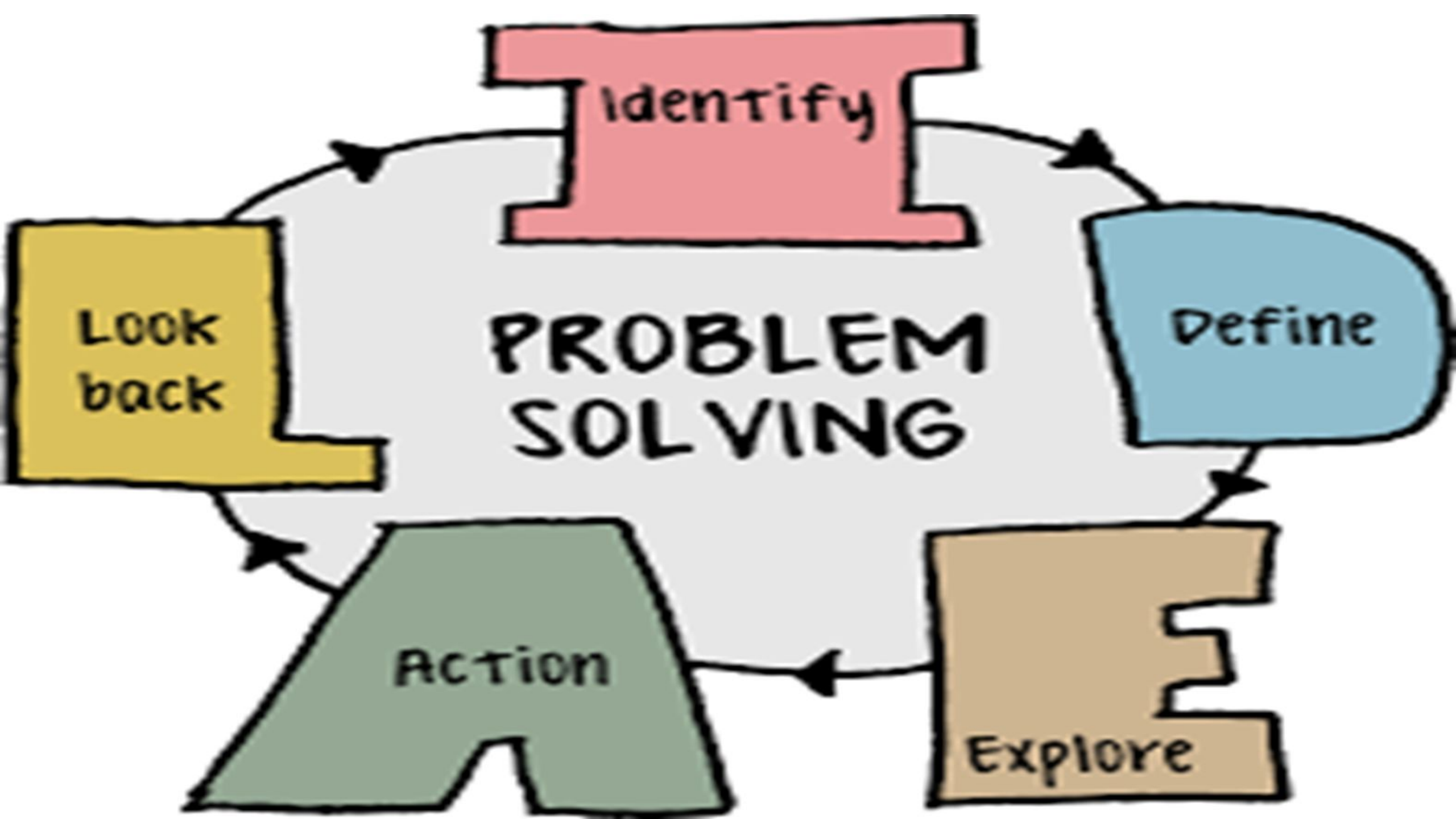
Legal

Problem Solving Skills

First step is to define your problem

Total Issues of the world

- Finance
- Relationship
- Collective to God
- Self management
- Skills
- Health
- Resource management
- Lack of progressiveness
- Peace
- System
- Identity crises



Problem Solving Techniques

- Knowledge
- Scholars
- Research
- Google
- Observation
- Consult
- Decision making